

As we mentioned above applications can have live tiles on the start screen that display changing data, and for this there is a new API for creating background tasks. There is also a new API for notifications, which are now natively supported by Windows—even by desktop applications.

Another interesting feature in Windows 8, is contracts. If your application manages some kind of data, you can provide a search contract, so that users can search for data handled by your application with ease. For example a photo management application might allow users to search for images by tags, file names and other data directly through Windows Search. A share contract will allow other applications to share data with your app. A twitter client for example, if it supports a search contract for sharing it will show up when a user tries to share data from another application—which also requires a search contract.

Windows also has the concept of extensions, which add features to Windows, for example by registering as handlers for AutoPlay, or as a provider of contact data, or as a handler of a particular file type. Also there is support for the plethora of sensors out there.

There are a number of other options available to developers. For example, they can take advantage of the fact that all Windows users running their WinRT-based application will have a Microsoft account. So if you don't have your own account system you can use that. You can also take advantage of features such as synchronization across computers using SkyDrive.

You may wonder, why would every Windows users running a WinRT application have a Microsoft account; well it's because of Microsoft's new Store, which is what we come to next.

Windows Store

The store is an integral part of Windows 8, as it the only way to discover, install, update or remove the new class of Windows applications that we have described before. This also means that it cannot itself be removed, at most it can be hidden.

The new Windows 8 applications running on WinRT cannot be installed without the store. The store in turn needs a Microsoft account in order to work, even if you only wish to install free applications. So essentially, you need a Microsoft account for even something as basic as installing a free app from the internet. This is actually quite common on mobile and tablet platforms, but now desktop users get a taste as well.

Standard desktop applications are not available in the store. While the store can list such applications—for this privilege the application needs Microsoft's certification—they cannot be

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installed from there. Actually, there is a way to side-load applications without the store, but it is mostly only applicable to enterprises running Windows 8.

For the new Windows tablets that run Windows RT, the only applications that can be run are WinRT-based applications. In fact the exception browsers enjoy on Windows 8 is not available to such apps and as such the only proper browser for Windows RT tablets is Internet Explorer. Which brings us neatly to Windows on ARM and tablets.

Windows on ARM

The availability of Windows on an entirely new architecture could have been a cause of celebration. Firstly Windows for ARM is not something you can buy in a store, it is only available to manufacturers to be delivered preinstalled on tablets. Even then what is available on ARM isn't really the traditional Windows.

Windows for ARM, or RT, includes only the new APIs and the new style of applications that are introduced with Windows 8, and cannot run traditional desktop applications even if they are compiled for ARM. So porting an existing application to Windows for ARM requires severe adaption of the UI to make it fit with the new style of applications.

Microsoft of course is exempt from this rule, and as such its own Office 2013 will be available for Windows RT, and will in fact come preinstalled. Also, its Internet Explorer for Windows RT has system access that enables it to perform much better than a traditional Metro application ever can.

This is important because if you were thinking of making a nice document editing app or an alternate browser for Windows tablets, Microsoft has you beat and they have more access than you will ever have.

However, Windows Phone 8 now uses the same Windows NT kernel as standard Windows 8. In fact it shares a lot of the WinRT APIs, making it easier to share and port code between Windows Phone 8 and Windows RT / 8.

Wrapping Up

Windows 8 is a significant release for developers, and offers new opportunities to developers in the form of a fresh, simple and new API for Windows, support for the increasingly popular web apps platform (HTML, CS, JS) and a new store for selling applications. However, there are many thorny issues, and only time will tell how popular Windows 8 will be. >

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